

done, you will be given a root shell prompt. From here, you will need to execute the correct commands and make a proper partition selection to install Slackware—remember, you generally don't have those *Back* buttons as in the case of the command line. This is the most complicated part—a single mistake here can format your earlier data. So, be very cautious while creating the partitions for installation.

fdisk or *cfdisk* are the two commands that can be used to partition the hard drive. I did it using *fdisk* because I am familiar with it—although *cfdisk* is more user-friendly, they say. Once partitions are created, you will have to type *setup* and hit *Enter* to begin the installation.

Next, it will ask you to format the partitions that you have created and you can also mount the other partitions in Slackware. The other non-Slackware partitions can be given permission like read/write/execute. Once you are done with all these, you can select CD-ROM as the source media for installing Slackware into your hard drive. You should then get an on-screen prompt asking for an auto (recommended) or manual device name (CD ROM) selection.

Slackware will also give you an option for selecting the packages, like *full*, *menu*, *expert*, *newbie*, *custom*, *tagpath* and *help*. I went with *full*, and the package installation started. The full installation takes around 5 GB of disk space. Anyway, it was time for me to get myself a cup of tea.

After the package installation is over—the procedure on my system took around 50 minutes—an on-screen text menu appears asking whether you want to use a USB device to boot Slackware. I chose to skip this option. Now comes the most critical part of the installation, the boot loader. In Slackware, the boot loader is still LILO—I told you, they don't change things if they are not broken—so no Grub. You must be very careful while installing LILO. During its installation, you are given three choices: simple, expert or else you can skip and install LILO later. I opted for the 'simple' option and then I chose the standard resolution for my screen. You will also be asked about the location to install LILO (root, floppy, MBR). I chose MBR. After that, you're prompted for the mouse, network, font configurations, hardware clock settings, time zone selection and default window manager for X. After the entire set up is done, you get a prompt saying 'Setup complete'. Now exit the installation and reboot your system by entering *init 6* from the root prompt.

The system boots into a text mode. In order to view the graphical interface, you will have to log in as the root and type *startx* or *kdm* to start the graphical desktop. I hit *kdm*, as *startx* would log me into the GUI directly as the root. On the KDM screen I released I have to create a user account first.

So, it was time to go back to the root shell by hitting *Ctrl+Alt+F1*. First, execute the following to create a user account:

```
# useradd -m abhijit
```

Abhijit happens to be *my* name. Remember to replace that with yours. Now, set the user account password with

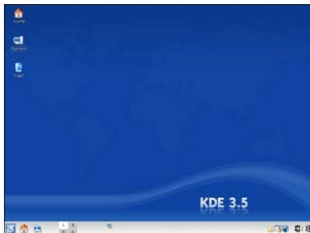


Figure 1: The default desktop

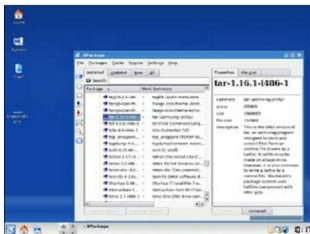


Figure 2: The KPackage utility

the *passwd* command.

This is the time to go back to the KDM screen—hit *Ctrl+Alt+F7*—select your desktop interface from the Menu button, where I chose KDE, and log in.

The Slack-perience

Slackware comes with KDE 3.5.10, which is the latest stable version from the KDE 3.x series. Figure 1 shows what the desktop looks like by default. This is actually the default KDE 3.5.10 desktop, including the wallpaper and the theme—Slackware hasn't even been customised to add a wallpaper of its own. Talk about conservatism! If you are a GTK sort of a person, your option is XFCE 4.4.3—sorry folks, no GNOME here!

As for the other important software, it comes with kernel 2.6.27.7, GCC 4.2.4 and Xorg server 1.4.2. Since I opted for a full installation, I noticed that whether you're a normal desktop user, a developer, or a sys admin, Slackware doesn't disappoint anyone—things are pretty much covered for everyone here.

There's really nothing much to report here—everything is in line with vanilla upstream versions (check sidebar for a list of available GUI applications).